

Chapter 62-1

Liang Shi stood in place for a long time, unable to move.

The wind blew from all directions, yet she felt an indescribable warmth.

Tears soaked through her shirt, falling on her skin, scalding hot, spreading all the way to her heart.

She opened her mouth wanting to speak, but couldn't utter a single word.

This emotion was too complex.

It had been a long time since she'd experienced such feelings.

It was as if an impenetrable wall had cracked open at this moment, and water flowed unrestrained through the fissure.

Flowing through her limbs and bones, leaving her entire being at a loss for what to do.

All the grievances she had endured before, the bitterness and pain she suffered when leaving that world, seemed to have found an outlet for release at this moment.

Those baseless curses, those insults that cut to the bone, those people who denied her efforts and her very existence.

She had worked so hard to avoid seeing those things, knowing that unplugging the internet would make it all irrelevant.

But those comments had destroyed her faith and ruined her dreams.

She considered herself to have never done anything wrong to anyone, yet those people didn't spare her despite her clear conscience.

Instead, they came at her like ocean waves, beating her to death on the shore, pulling her into the tide.

She was powerless to resist.

Yet had no choice but to accept it.

Sister Wang¹ had once told her that in this profession, one must endure what ordinary people cannot endure, and bear what ordinary people cannot bear.

If you can't handle others' curses, then quit early.

So she had accepted being cursed as part of the job.

But she had also wondered quietly in the depths of night—are criticism and cursing the same thing?

Bad acting can be criticized, but why curse?

Was it because they were truly angry, or just to vent their emotions?

After countless times of denying herself, she picked up her confidence countless times again.

She made herself into what she was now, able to pretend not to care while doing this job, reading others' comments, whether good or bad.

Even after reading them, she could still comfort Xu Qingzhu.

She had made herself impenetrable.

But now, it seemed like someone cared about her.

Someone empathized with everything she had suffered, someone would worry about her being subjected to those curses and insults, so they advised her not to step into that circle anymore.

Liang Shi's heart was filled with mixed emotions, and her eyes had also reddened from the wind.

After a long while, she wrapped one arm around Xu Qingzhu in return, still smiling as she comforted, "It's okay, everything will pass."

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Xu Qingzhu also knew she had lost composure and closed her eyes on the way back, pretending to doze.

Liang Shi didn't expose her either, driving the car all the way back to Shallow Water Bay.

The online public opinion was still fermenting. Xu Qingzhu went to Chen Liuying's Weibo comments section for a stroll and discovered that Chen Liuying had already closed her Weibo comments.

Bai Weiwei's was the same.

But all netizens were still cursing while trending hashtags, presumably receiving many private messages as well.

When Liang Shi brought her hot milk, she found Xu Qingzhu looking at this and asked, "Does it make you sad?"

"For whom?" Xu Qingzhu put her phone on the bed, took the milk and gently sipped it. Her lips were stained with a layer of white, and she stuck out her tongue tip to lick it off, then asked in return, "Bai Weiwei?"

Liang Shi nodded.

After all, they had once been good friends.

"Not really." Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly, then quickly relaxed, "Perhaps everyone is selfish. When she chose to confront me online, all the affection between us was gone. I can't feel sorry for her."

She said "can't," not "don't feel sorry."

Liang Shi noticed the difference in that single word and raised an eyebrow, "Can't?"

"That's right, can't." Xu Qingzhu said, "Feeling sorry for her would mean denying all of your efforts today. I can only say that people must pay the price for their actions, so there's nothing to feel sorry about."

Liang Shi nodded, "Very true."

Xu Qingzhu held the glass cup with both hands, and after a while, shifted the topic to tonight's incident, "Teacher Liang, just pretend I never said that."

"Said what?" Liang Shi didn't react for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, "About asking you not to enter the entertainment industry."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I just feel like public figures seem to have to accept too many things." Xu Qingzhu said, "Those things make people... very unhappy."

"I know." Liang Shi smiled slightly. She stood in the doorway, the dim light casting a halo around her face, "So, thank you."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled, "Thank me for what?"

"Nothing." Liang Shi felt too embarrassed to pierce through that layer of pretense. Once said, both would be awkward, and there was no need.

"Go to sleep early." Liang Shi reminded her.

Xu Qingzhu's clear eyes stared at her, and only when she was about to leave did she say, "Liang Shi, if you see those unhappy things in the future, you can also talk to me about them."

Liang Shi originally wanted to politely decline, but when she met the sincerity in those eyes, her words took a turn, and she said gently, "Okay."

¹ Sister Wang (王姐) - A respectful way to address an older woman colleague or mentor, particularly common in professional settings in China